

From: [Francesco Erriques](#)
To: [Francesco Erriques](#); british_language@libero.it; [Erriques Francesco](#)
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Good morning! You've hit on one of the most profound conceptual shifts in the history of geometry: the transition from **extrinsic geometry** (looking at a surface from the outside) to **intrinsic geometry** (measuring things entirely from within the surface).

To see how Riemann and Ricci managed to bypass the normal vector field, we have to look at what the normal field actually *did* for Gauss, and how Riemann found an internal surrogate for it.

1. The Extrinsic View: Gauss and the Normal Field

In the Gaussian approach, a surface M is embedded inside a higher-dimensional Euclidean space (like a 2D sheet inside $\mathbb{R}^3$).

To understand how the surface curves, Gauss looked at how the **unit normal vector field** N changes as you move along the surface. This change is captured by the **Shape Operator** (or Weingarten map) $S(X) = -\nabla_X N$, which directly feeds into the **Second Fundamental Form**:

$$II(X, Y) = \langle S(X), Y \rangle = \langle -\nabla_X N, Y \rangle$$

The normal vector acts as a literal "anchor" to the outside world. It gives you a baseline to say, "*Ah, the surface is bending away from this normal vector.*" The breakthrough came when Gauss proved his *Theorema Egregium*: the total curvature (Gaussian curvature K) can actually be computed solely by measuring angles and distances *on* the surface (the First Fundamental Form), without ever knowing how it bends into $\mathbb{R}^3$.

2. The Intrinsic View: Riemann's Parallel Transport

Bernhard Riemann took Gauss's hint and ran with it. He asked: *If we lived inside a manifold and had no access to an outside embedding—and therefore no normal vector field—how could we measure curvature?*

The answer lies in how tangent vectors behave when you move them around a closed loop, a concept formalised later as **parallel transport**.

Instead of watching a normal vector change from the outside, Riemann watched how *tangent* vectors change from the inside.

The Levi-Civita Connection

Without an ambient space, you cannot use standard calculus to differentiate vectors. Instead, we use a **connection** ∇ (specifically the Levi-Civita connection). If you project the standard directional derivative in $\mathbb{R}^3$ onto the tangent plane of the surface, you get this intrinsic derivative:

$$\nabla_X Y = \left(\partial_X Y \right)^{\text{tangential}}$$

Notice what is missing here: the normal component! The second fundamental form is exactly the normal piece we threw away: $\partial_X Y = \nabla_X Y + II(X, Y)N$. Riemann realized he didn't need that normal piece to detect curvature.

The Riemann Curvature Tensor

If a space is perfectly flat (like a Euclidean plane), taking a vector, parallel-transporting it along a path, and bringing it back to the start yields the exact same

vector. Furthermore, the order in which you take directional derivatives doesn't matter.

If the space is curved, derivatives fail to commute, and a transported vector will experience a "twist" or rotation when it returns to its starting point.

The **Riemann Curvature Tensor** $R(X,Y)Z$ measures this failure to commute precisely:

$$R(X,Y)Z = \nabla_X \nabla_Y Z - \nabla_Y \nabla_X Z - \nabla_{[X,Y]} Z$$
Because the connection ∇ is purely intrinsic (constructed entirely from the metric tensor g_{ij} and its derivatives via Christoffel symbols), **$R(X,Y)Z$ requires absolutely no reference to a normal vector field or an embedding space.** It defines curvature as an internal tension of the manifold itself.

3. Passing to the Ricci Tensor: Averaging the Curvature

While the Riemann tensor tells you *everything* about the intrinsic curvature, it is a massive, highly redundant 4th-rank tensor (R^a_{bcd}). In n dimensions, it has $\frac{n^2(n^2-1)}{12}$ independent components.

To make this geometric information more digestible, Gregorio Ricci-Curbastro introduced a way to "average" this curvature by taking a trace (contraction).

The **Ricci Tensor** $\text{Ric}(X,Y)$ reduces this complexity. Geometrically, if you take a tangent vector X , the Ricci tensor evaluates the average sectional curvature of all 2-dimensional planes that contain X . Mechanically, it contracts the Riemann tensor:

$$\text{Ric}(X,Y) = \sum_{i=1}^n \langle R(e_i, X)Y, e_i \rangle$$
Where $\{e_i\}$ is an orthonormal basis of the tangent space.

What does the Ricci Tensor measure without a normal?

If you start at a point and fire a small sphere of geodesics (freely falling particles) in all directions, the Ricci tensor measures how the **volume** of that distorted sphere deviates from the volume of a perfect sphere in flat Euclidean space as it moves forward.

If $\text{Ric}(X,X) > 0$, the geodesics bend toward each other (converge), and the volume shrinks faster than in flat space.

If $\text{Ric}(X,X) < 0$, they diverge, and the volume grows faster.

Summary of the Shift

Geometric Tool	Extrinsic (Gauss)	Intrinsic (Riemann / Ricci)
Reference Point	The ambient space's straight lines via the Normal Vector N .	The manifold's own straight lines via Geodesics .
Measurement	How much the tangent space <i>tilts</i> relative to the normal ($\text{II}(X,Y)$).	How much a tangent vector <i>rotates</i> when parallel transported around a loop ($R(X,Y)Z$).
Core Object	Shape Operator / Second Fundamental Form.	Metric Tensor g_{ij} $\rightarrow$ Levi-Civita Connection ∇ .

By shifting the definition of curvature from "*how a space bends in a room*" to "*how vectors twist when walked in a loop*," Riemann and Ricci freed geometry from the shackles of higher dimensions, setting the exact mathematical stage Einstein needed for General Relativity.

Would you like to explore how the Riemann tensor explicitly links back to Gauss's $\mathcal{K}$ in the specific case of a 2D surface, or dive into the index notation of these tensors?